PRIORITY 16 OF 33 · SCORE 3.0

National Science Foundation

NSF is a grant maker with excellent public award data. Fraud risks are duplicate funding of the same research across agencies, SBIR award mills, and undisclosed conflicts. It is a cheap addition to the cross-agency SBIR screen and a good place to test text-similarity methods.

INVESTIGATIONS WE PROPOSE

- **NSF-1** Test bed for the duplicate-award method. **First prototype.**
- **NSF-2** Award mills and repeat PIs.
- **NSF-3** Links to excluded parties and settled cases.

EXPOSURE

- $8.1B in outlays in FY2026.
- GAO found 842 of 10,570 SBIR/STTR awardees (almost 8%) had four or more fraud risk indicators and about $445M in possibly duplicative awards across agencies (2024).

PUBLIC DATA WE USE

- **NSF Award Search:** every award with abstract, PI and institution.
- **SBIR.gov** award data; **NIH RePORTER** for cross-agency overlap.
- **NSF OIG** reports and investigations.

HOW WE DETECT IT

1. **Duplicate research:** near-identical abstracts funded by NSF and other agencies.
2. **Award mills:** firms or PIs with many awards and little output.
3. **Network links** to excluded parties or settled cases.

FIRST PROTOTYPE

Use NSF as the test bed for the cross-agency duplicate-award screen.

SCORECARD

Fraud savings identified
● Pending

Phase 1 window
Weeks 9–12
Jan 11, 2027 to Feb 5, 2027

Workstream
Shared screens

FY2026 outlays
$8.1B · budget rank 26

Leads go to
NSF OIG

WHY PRIORITY 16

Exposure	●●○○○
Public data	●●●●○
SBA method fit	●●●●○
Actionability	●●○○○

OUR REVIEW, DELIVERED WEEK 12

Use NSF data to tune the text-similarity method first (week 9), then run across all agencies.

Every lead goes to an Inspector General or DOJ as a referral package with sources and caveats. Nothing is published.

WHAT WE ASK OF NSF

Phase 2 data: Full proposals and budgets, PI current-and-pending support.

What it enables: Duplicate funding at the proposal level.

Access route: Each OIG.

LIMITS

Some topical overlap is legitimate; leads need program officer review.

SOURCES

- GAO-24-105470: SBIR/STTR fraud vulnerabilities
- NSF Award Search
- USAspending agency profiles (FY2026 outlays)

Scores and plans are our judgment from public sources. Risk indicators are leads for Inspectors General or DOJ, not accusations.

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